Murder mystery character

John Paul Winston George Montgomery Randolph sat inconspicuously near the gate for Flight 487 to London's Heathrow airport. He was 23 but could have passed for his late teens but for his sallow eyes, a scraggly unshaven beard, unkempt hair, and clothes that were ill fitting on a lean frame and always having that "wash and wear" look falling somewhere between wrinkled and pressed.

Beside him was a small carry-on and a "portfolio tube" like an artist might carry for rolled artwork. On first glance he might be mistaken for a homeless person who somehow scored an airplane ticket. But his passport, issued in 2019 gave evidence of extensive international travel. He was clearly not homeless — just a kid with means who was totally indifferent in his attire and looks.

John Paul, "JP", or "Win" (and other names the family had tried out on him over the years that never seemed to stick) preferred to be called "D" — short for his social media handle "Doom 2005". He was the odd one out in his family.

His father, Frederick Randolph, was a internationally famous neurosurgeon. His mother, Amanda (*nee* Montgomery) Randolph was a principal partner in Cocke & James, a high-powered law firm fixing problems for Fortune 10 corporations globally. Frederick and Amanda met when he was doing a fellowship at National Hospital for Neurology and Neurosurgery (NHNN) at Queen Square, part of University College London Hospitals (UCLH). Amanda had just completed her LLB Laws from the London School of Economics including her year abroad in Washington DC. Although Frederick was, himself, from northern Virginia, they did not encounter each other during Amanda's year in DC — although when they did meet they discovered that there was a significant overlap in their respective social circles. Frederick had been at Harvard Medical School and doing his neurosurgery residency at Massachusetts General Hospital in Boston.

After a fairly rapid courtship, Frederick and Amanda married and had two children, Sarah and Richard, within the first four years of marriage. They settled in Bethesda, Maryland where Frederick performed neurosurgery variously at Walter Reed, John Hopkins, and Georgetown and also international cases as his skill became known and in demand. Frederick was one of the Virginia Randolphs, so he was always economically secure. The home in Bethesda was expansive and the weekend home in McClean included stables and pastures. Amanda was not a doting mother, but their economic status permitted a housekeeper, nanny and chauffeur so that the children were well looked after. And Sarah and Richard seemed to have inherited their parents' self-reliance, discipline and ambition so that achievement came easily.

“D” was a surprise baby when Amanda was 45 years old. Sarah was by now 15 and Richard 12 when “D” came along. By the time “D” was in kindergarten his siblings were mostly missing from the home. Sarah followed her mother into law and Richard followed his father into medicine. Amanda was busy with her law practice, but the housekeeper, nanny and chauffeur were “D”s constant companions. Both Amanda and Frederick travelled internationally for their work although most times not to the same location or at the same time. But “D” and the nanny might accompany Amanda on some of her trips to London, Geneva, Brussels, or Beijing. And there were occasional family “vacations” in Europe with Frederick and Amanda together. “D” had a passport as soon as he was eligible. Sarah and/or Richard were rarely on trips with “D” once they were away in school and embarked on their careers and he had little memory of traveling with them when he was very young.

For whatever reason “D” was indifferent about everything — school, clothing, socializing. One of “D”’s high school teacher had warned him about becoming a “drifter”. But “D” seemed to take the warning less as a caution than as a goal. “Drifting” was as good a description of “D” as there was.

“D” wondered at times whether he was *damaged* — born as he was to a peri-menopausal mother. He never felt he really belonged in his family. Everyone was an over-achiever. He didn’t really want for anything. His parents remained focus on what they did and expected him to progress as his siblings had done. But he didn’t. He was sure his parents had given up on him.

He went from an indifferent student in high school to an indifferent student at Montgomery College near his Bethesda home. Montgomery was the college that accepted everyone and was happy to lecture you if you showed or simply take your money if you didn’t. And, he didn’t. So transferring to a more prestigious university was not an option. In fact, he really didn’t care.

He was content to amuse himself as he would. He was active on Reddit “incel” (involuntary celibate) websites until they were shut down and he moved over to Discord. He was not technically an incel. He wasn’t a virgin. A combination of promiscuity and alcohol in a teen girl at a high school house party had done the deed. But “D” was never comfortable with girls, and his general *ennui* overcame his hormones and focused his attention on the internet.

When his parents finally discovered that “D” was not going anywhere academically they bought him a brownstone in Old Alexandria, set up a trust fund, and only demanded that he provide proof of life four times a year — Mother’s Day, Christmas, Easter, and Thanksgiving. Otherwise he was on his

own. His trust fund fed his Apple Pay and within a year he was living a totally digital life.

He was active in the Discord community with his handle “Doom2005”. His IRL (in real life) circle was nearly non-existent. Although there were some people he would repeatedly see at the neighborhood Starbucks, no names were exchanged. He did see some recurring characters delivering his Door Dash or Uber Eats. But, again, no names just whatever labels appeared on his apps — which may or may not be real names. He always went by just “D” — although the people who inspected his governmental ID would know his true name.

One group that he started spending more time with was called “Bambi”. The group picked that name to deflect from their real focus: anarchy, pranks, disruption and fascination with violence. The group’s administrator went by the handle “Great Prince” — a reference to Bambi’s father in the story known as The Great Prince of the Forest. While most of the time the group simply shared posts about events around the world that reflected their focus, every once in a while Great Prince would call for an “op”. Two or three group members would be sent on errands with cryptic instructions and then later a post would appear about a local event — a prank, graffiti, vandalism, or disruption — that Great Prince would announce was the doing of “Bambi”.

April was always a big month for “ops” what with April Fools, Tax Day, Hitler’s Birthday and Earth Day all being in April. So it was that “D” was not surprised when Great Prince reached out to him around April 19 for an “op”. He was to go to the Rise Up Coffee — Market House coffee shop in Annapolis on Saturday morning to meet “Joe” who would have an artists’ portfolio tube with him. “D” would get a cup of coffee and approach the guy and simply say “Joe ?” The guy would then respond “oh Hi!” in recognition, “D” would sit with “Joe” until they finished their coffee. After finishing his coffee “Joe” would exit the coffee shop leaving the tube behind. “D” would then finish his coffee and take the tube back home with him. Further instructions would be sent him later.

“D” performed the task. He was mildly surprised when he was instructed to take the tube and fly to Amsterdam with it on May 12. “D” was a little startled by this. All the prior ops he had been involved in were all local. So, Europe? He couldn’t recall anything he had said that would let anyone know he could travel out of the country on a moments’ notice. But clearly Great Prince knew. How did he know it?

These questions didn’t rise as concerns. Instead, he reviewed in his head the kind of conversations that went on in “Bambi” and began to wonder if it wasn’t just a cell of a larger organization. If so, what was it? Antifa, FAU, CNT-F, other?

As he though it over “D” enjoyed seeing himself as a cog in what he could only imagine was a larger machine. Was he a foot-soldier in a cause so large and important that no one could be trusted with the full picture? Each foot-soldier had to be ready to respond when called.

His parents and siblings thought themselves so important, but when their world came crashing down he might reveal to them that it was *he* who had played a role in that destruction and made all of their accomplishment and status to be nothing at all.

And so it was, “D” sat waiting for Flight 487. Next to him was the portfolio tube. Inside the tube? Great Prince hadn’t instructed “D” not to look, so he had. Various printed posters — the type you might find at any gallery store or poster shop. Was there some hidden message in one or more of the posters? “D” didn’t know. Maybe this was just a test run to see if he could carry out such an op. He didn’t know. But he knew he was on a mission and he was determined to succeed.